The Last Five Years

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/75942921.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra), mentioned Scorpia/Perfuma, mentioned Mermista/Sea Hawk - Relationship, mentioned Netossa/Spinnerella - Relationship

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Breaking Up & Making Up, Adora is an author, Catra is a theater actor, or whatever the word is, google didn't help, no beta we die like shadow weaver, not that she is in this, I mean she is, she gets like two vague mentions, but not named, anyway my tags are chaotic i'm sorry, How Do I Tag, author is awkward as hell, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Happy Ending, Hopeful Ending, not sure which one is accurate, a bit of cursing, I'm sure no job I'm portraying is accurate, I just took what the musical gave me and didn't ask questions

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The Last Five Years

by MessTrudi

Summary

Catra and Adora are over. They have spent their lives together for five years, and now they're done.
Just where did they go wrong? Time for both of them to review.

A fanfic inspired by the musical "The Last Five Years" just with less cheating (read none) and a happier ending because don't even think for a second I would actually separate these two.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

Hi!! This is my first time posting for this fandom, so I'll mention that English is my second language, and I apologize for any mistakes in advance.

Apart from that, I wanted to explain the structure of this because if you don't know the musical, I'm afraid it might be confusing... also, I have changed the structure just a little bit to fit the story more, making it possibly even more confusing than originally! Or maybe I'm just overthinking ¯_(ツ)_/¯

Anyway, so we'll start at the end and then move just a little bit into the past to the breakup. (Any jump in time is marked by the three ***. The one time I used *~~~* I tried to indicate that we're still in the same time, but a different perspective.)
Then, after that, we jump between Catra and Adora, reminiscing about their relationship (not much to see in this chapter, but I'm still telling you). Adora moves from their first meeting forward, while Catra moves from their last meeting backwards.

I hope that makes sense... if not, please feel free to yell at me in the comments <333

Also, this fic was originally supposed to be shorter, but as long as it turned out, I decided to put it into four chapters and really tried not to mess up the flow of the story too much. I'll also try to upload this in short succession!!

Now, I hope you have fun!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was alone in their apartment and cried. She had done nothing else for the last few days.

When she had come home that day, somehow she thought she would be over it sooner, but she probably should have expected that five years were not so easily forgotten and moved on from.

At this point, though, she had to get it together. She had to get out of bed, maybe take a shower, and then she had to make it to work. She couldn't miss the premiere.

The problem was just that crying in bed felt … well, not better, but certainly easier.

She should have never asked Adora to meet her, at least that way they could have broken up *after* Catra didn't have such an important event coming up. But she had hoped, and now it was over. They were over.

Catra went back to bawling into her pillow. It must be hers. Adora had barely been home at all the last few months, meaning everything in this bed had not been touched by the blonde — a fact that had bothered her, but now she was grateful for it.

Her phone rang again, and she ignored it again. She knew who was calling and it wasn't Adora, so it didn't matter. Adora was already somewhere across the country, probably happy to finally be rid of her. It was Scorpia, wanting to know where Catra was — the show started in two hours and she still lay in bed and cried. Because her stupid wife couldn't care less about her.

It was a long time coming. It hadn't been much of a surprise either that they had fought and that they had broken up. Well, Catra had yelled, not much of a fight, but a big disappointment anyway.

Somehow, she has had the tiniest bit of hope left that Adora would not prioritize her career over the woman she had vowed to spend her life with. It had been delusional to think Catra actually mattered.

Her phone rang again with a hundred worried messages from Scorpia telling her how freaked out everyone was.

Catra took a deep breath and willed the tears to stop. She had a show tonight. Her first job as a performer and it was big, too. A leading role in a sold-out theater.

Adora wouldn't ruin this for her. Not after years of failed auditions, while the blonde climbed higher and higher and left her behind. Catra would get out of bed and on that stage, and she should be fabulous and get a standing ovation, no matter how much her life was falling apart.

Five years down the drain hurt already, but it would hurt a lot more if she threw the work she had done in that time out the window, too.

It didn't take long to put on a clean shirt and get outside — she could do everything else inside the theater when everyone else was calmed down by her presence. How did the saying go? The show must go on.

She had been to countless auditions to get here, had worked her ass off for months and she was not letting all that go to waste just because of a little heartbreak.

Catra ran down the stairs and didn't plan on stopping before she stood in front of the theater, but when she came outside, an odd sight greeted her. There was a car parked in front of the building. Adora's car.

For a second, she let herself be confused by it before she stalked off. Adora probably took a taxi because it was more convenient or something. There was no way she had actually wasted a thought on Catra.

She could drive, of course, but she would be damned if she took that car. The bus would get her where she needed to be just the same and it would hold fewer memories.

It didn't matter that public transport was dirty and terrible and loud. Right now, it was nicer to listen to other people's problems than think about her marriage falling apart. Yet, it didn't seem to

want to leave her mind. She always thought that in her line of work, she had to be a masochist, but this confirmed it. Her brain kept torturing her with her idiotic delusion that she had honestly thought they could fix things.

***

She sat in a park. Catra didn't hate the park, or anything, but it was a bit … she didn't even have the word for it. She didn't like it. Maybe for a nice Sunday afternoon stroll, but not for her birthday.

Of course, it would have been nice if Adora had thought of something, planned something even, but meeting in the park was nice. Fresh air, it was starting to get cooler, the leaves looked pretty and there weren't too many people around.

Catra could settle for this — with as little as they saw each other, she would gladly take any time spent together, no matter where.

Besides, it wasn't just the park. They would go out to eat somewhere, have a slow night, watch a movie, and cuddle, maybe more if the mood was right. And she really wanted to talk.

Things have been distant lately. They were both busy, that was impractical, but even apart from that, they just weren't as close as they had been once. Whenever they were in the same space, they fought or didn't talk at all. It was starting to get to her, but she wasn't ready to give up on them yet.

If only Adora would finally show up.

Catra was starting to freeze and if she couldn't get walking soon, she would go home. Luckily, she saw the blonde ponytail round a corner and smiled with relief. It was fine, they were here, and together, and they would be okay.

"Hey, Adora", she called out and received a smile in return. Maybe she had been overthinking this. "It's nice to see you", she said awkwardly, as if it were their first date. It might as well be, considering how little the other was around nowadays.

"You look nice", Adora responded and held out her hand.

Catra took it and they finally started strolling. "I look like Daisy May", she responded then. She hated this shirt. "Pretty sure, I stole this sweater." They were both laughing. They would be okay. "Adora", she got brave then. "We- I know things haven't been easy, but I want to make this work again. And we can do that, I know we can. We'll just have to try a bit harder. And I mean, you're here. That means something." She took a breath, trying to make sense, but she wasn't sure if she was succeeding. "I'll try to keep my anger in check, and I'll own when I was wrong. We can start this weekend and … we'll be fine."

Adora didn't answer for a few long seconds, making Catra's anxiety spike. "About your show", she then said. Carefully. Like she had bad news to deliver. "I, uh… I kinda had a call earlier and there's this… thing and my agent said it's important. I'm sorry. But it falls on Saturday."

She really couldn't blow this a minute after she said she would try to be more chill. So, she swallowed down her frustrations. "Yeah, whatever, if you have to, then … you have to", she said and heard her voice strain with the attempt to stay calm. It was too soon to fail her resolution, this wasn't New Year's. "We'll start today, then. Baby steps", she compromised and tried to believe it herself.

A sigh. "About that…"

"Adora", she warned, already losing her battle against her anger. If the blonde were smart, she would shut up now.

"I had to book a flight for tonight, or I won't make it. Every other day is completely booked, probably people going home for

Halloween", the woman defended herself and Catra felt something inside her snap.

"Are you serious?" She ripped her hand away, so she could face the other properly. "I can't do this anymore! We could be together for one day, just one, and you chose someone else is more important than me."

"That's not-", Adora started, but Catra already lost her cool. There was no way the blonde could defend herself anymore.

"It's exactly what you're doing!", she yelled, not caring about other passersby staring. "You could be here with me, but instead you fly out to go to another party, filled with the same jerks you already know. You know, you could stay with your wife on her fucking birthday and you could — god forbid — even see my show. But no, your career is important, your books, your parties. Everything is always about you!"

She had to take a breath since she was starting to run out of air and she shot Adora a look, daring her to use the break, but the woman looked too stunned to speak.

"And when I ask you to see my show, you don't care. Just like you don't care about my birthday, or my friends. Do you even have any idea what it's like to be constantly asked about you?! And I don't just mean the reporters telling me how great you are as if I'm living under a fucking rock! Do you know what it's like to explain to my friends, let alone yours, why my wife is not coming to their birthdays or graduation parties? To explain to them that you're somewhere across the country getting drunk and I-"

Her breathing got more erratic and she felt her throat tighten when the first tears started to fall. Somehow her anger turned into pure desperation.

Adora said nothing. She just stood there and watched, looking slightly shellshocked.

Catra took a few breaths, trying and failing to calm down. "Just go", she then said.

"Catra…"

She waited, still so stupidly hopeful, but nothing followed. "I'm not forcing you to stay here. Go. Get drunk, get praised. I… I don't care anymore", she said, wiping the tears that kept coming. "Maybe it's for the best this way."

"Catra?" It sounded genuinely shocked. It didn't matter. Not anymore.

"You know what's the worst part?", she asked, barely able to stand tall, but she forced her spine to hold her up. "I've been there, at your parties. I cancelled auditions and callbacks, all to support you. And you can't even stay a single night." She shook her head. "I can't do this anymore. Go. Fly god knows where and if you come back… we should see a lawyer."

She just walked away then. Left the park without even once turning around to see Adora's reaction. She couldn't risk seeing her smile happily or being relieved. No one yelled after her, no one apologized. If not for the bustling city around her, she would have left in complete silence.

Her memories of how she got back to their apartment were blurry. All she knew was that she broke down the second the door closed shut.

Just like that, it was over.

The next few hours, Catra cried and debated calling Adora, to… she didn't even know, because she surely wasn't going to apologize. It was just that she already missed her. The same dumb feeling that made her want to compromise was now very persistently guiding her hand to the call button. But every time, her finger hovered uselessly, and she reminded herself how uncared for she was feeling.

Unsurprisingly, no one else came home that night. Or the next.

By the third day, she did call someone — Scorpia, who probably still didn't know what was going on because Catra could barely speak through her sobs, but her friend tried to be supportive anyway.

It made her feel at least good enough to also call the pizza place down the road. She was out of chips to sustain herself with.

She was alone. It wasn't a particularly new feeling since Adora had been away more and more often, but it was still different. Because this would be permanent.

It was for the best, she kept telling herself. Maybe someday she would actually believe it.

~~~

Adora didn't know how long she stood there in the park, staring after Catra, who had vanished a long time ago.

This hadn't been at all how she thought this would go. She hadn't had a lot of expectations at all, to be fair, but this was still not what she had expected. She probably should have.

Things had been strained, she knew that, and Catra had every right to be angry at her. Especially considering the news she had dropped on the other, but usually they always worked it out. She should have known there would be an end to it eventually.

The sun was already setting and she barely felt her feet anymore. Her phone vibrated with a reminder to head to the airport, but she still couldn't move from her spot.

Catra's last words rang in her head. If she came back. If. Like the woman really believed that she would just abandon her like this. That even if it came to it, Adora wouldn't make sure the other was taken care of.

That lack of faith hit her harder than all the other things she had been accused of. Well, it was true, so it wasn't really an accusation.

Adora had been so swept up in her books and promotion that she- No, she had noticed that Catra had gotten unhappy. She just hadn't realized how bad it was. And how much of it was her fault.

She should have paid more attention. She should have done a lot of things. It was too late now.

Her phone vibrated again. The sun was down now and the only light illuminating her was a streetlamp. She practically already missed her flight.

And she was too stuck in her shock to truly care. She didn't care about the flight, the party, her agent, or her fingers about to fall off because they were frozen. The only thing that mattered was that she had messed up. A lot.

Eventually, a swan or a goose made some noise from the little pond and effectively startled her out of her state. She looked over to where the sound had come from and saw a bird come straight for her.

At least the possible incoming threat managed to get her out of the park before that thing would bite her or something. It wasn't exactly closing time yet, but it seemed the animals here still wanted to be left alone.

She got into her car, and despite the slightly grounding wake-up call, she quickly went back into her daze. Somehow, she managed to safely drive to their apartment building despite of it.

Adora even got out of the car, but when she stood in front of the entrance, she froze again. Taking a few steps back, she looked up. There was light, so Catra must be home. That at least put her at ease a little, to know that the other had made it here safely, too.

Call her a coward, but she turned around and began walking down the street. She debated what she was supposed to do now if she wasn't going to confront Catra, but also missed her flight. She didn't want to sleep in her car, even if she probably deserved it.

If she really tried, she could probably find another flight somewhere, squeeze herself into the last available seat, but… she didn't feel like going anywhere.

For now, she checked into the next best hotel she came across. She had no clothes, no other belongings apart from her wallet, phone and keys. She didn't even have a charger. There were a few odd looks for that circumstance from the front desk lady and some other guests, but they let her stay regardless, and she didn't care much either.

She spotted some couple in the corner whispering and when she looked over, she saw a glimpse of her own book in the guy's hands. Whether they were trying to decide to come talk to her or theorize about why she showed up like a homeless person, she didn't know and she wasn't planning on finding out.

Still in a slight daze, the shock not having left her yet, she dragged herself to her room and crashed on the bed, staring at the ceiling. What was she supposed to do now?

***

Adora was fresh out of college and freshly into fighting her parents on her career choice. It had been a few months, in all fairness, but it still felt fresh considering how little progress she had made.

Her parents supported her, of course, but they would like her to choose something a bit more secure. Being an author was admirable, but not exactly connected to a steady income. Unless she managed to make it big. She was, allegedly, wasting her potential.

She didn't have the delusions and necessary ego to think she would actually be a really famous author one day, but even an author with a small but steady fan base could make a good enough income to be secure, and that's what she was hoping for, currently.

But how was she supposed to do that if her parents were constantly breathing down her neck?

So, she had searched for a different place to write. The library was nice, quiet, and if she lacked inspiration, she could just read something. Sometimes, though, it was too quiet for her liking, her own thoughts running rampant and not being able to focus on the page she was trying to fill. Also, the librarian hated her. It seemed like that woman hated everyone, but it made her uncomfortable.

Adora had moved to some small coffee shop on the other end of town then.

She hadn't expected much out of it, just enough distraction to keep her mind busy, while also chill enough to still get something done. In the end, it did fulfill that small list of requirements, but what actually made her stay was the barista.

Meeting Catra had been like meeting a goddess. She was gorgeous and witty, even as a tired customer service worker, and she didn't take bullshit from anyone. At the beginning, Adora worried about that, but she soon learned that nobody really cared.

Most regulars simply had a yelling match with her, ending in some hearty laughter, and even newcomers seemed to kind of appreciate the attitude, sick and tired of the fake niceness this city had to give.

The few Karen's that did demand to meet the manager were swiftly thrown out by said manager — Adora thinks her name was Netossa, and she had a similar no bullshit attitude as Catra, which made them an incredibly in tune team.

Adora never drank more coffee in her life than in those few months. She also has never had such a creativity boost. And she had never spent so much time outside of her house, either.

School and even college had been a routine of going there and coming straight back. Sometimes she hung out with her friends, but none of that could rival her being here during the entire opening hours from eight to six. Catra didn't even work for all of that.

So, yeah, she spent most of her time in this coffee shop writing and staring at the pretty girl behind the counter — luckily for her, they also served cake, so she at least didn't starve.

Adora didn't just stare like a creep, though. They bantered, as Catra did with every regular — which she had quickly become after essentially moving her entire life to the third table by the window — and she also overheard conversations like a creep. Not that Catra seemed to be too mad about that whenever Adora let something slip.

It wasn't that creepy, either. The building was tiny and the space limited, so who could blame her if she, maybe coincidentally, overheard a few talks between the woman and her coworkers and customers, she assumed were friends.

At least this way, she learned something about her crush. Catra obviously wasn't very passionate about the coffee-making industry, and Adora learned it was just a side hustle to pay rent

while she tried to get cast in any theater production — the woman wasn't picky.

She also learned that they were about the same age, that Catra had a troubled past, and that she was piss poor.

Here's the thing, Adora couldn't care less about that last part, and her family wasn't by any means rich, but they were doing well… really well. Her parents combined earned more money than her friend's mom, who was the mayor. The thing was, that she knew her parents wouldn't exactly approve of anyone so far out of their circle — even Bow had been a long process and his dads were accomplished historians!

And somehow that circumstance made her want to ask out the other woman even more.

And who wouldn't? Catra had studied politics and art, she was smart and quick-witted and beautiful and gentle — she would deny it, but Adora spent enough time here to have seen the woman lose the tough facade whenever a child was present.

Adora had been so caught up, gushing over Catra and daydreaming about how she would ask her out, that she barely noticed the woman come over and sit in front of her.

"Hey, Adora", she said, giving her a once-over, making her effectively freeze with her fingers above her keyboard. "What exactly are you doing?", she then asked, her eyebrows raised expectantly.

"Uh…", she mumbled, willing her brain to function again. "What am I supposed to be doing?", she replied carefully.

Catra snorted, a sound that really shouldn't be so pretty. Adora was screwed. "You sit here all day, every day, annoy me to no end, order six coffees and enough cakes to feed half this city, and you type away on that thing", she pointed out. "So, I wanna know what it is you're doing."

"Oh", she breathed out, relieved. For a moment, she had thought her crush had been caught and Catra was here to reject her or something. "I'm writing. I uh, wanna publish, become an author." It sounded so awkward when she said it, like she was questioning it herself.

"Really? That's cool", the brunette answered to her surprise. "Anything finished yet? With as much time as you spend here, you probably wrote five books already."

Adora laughed, her shocked state having worn off. "I'm not that fast", she confessed. Not to mention that she gets distracted by the woman in front of her way too often.

"I noticed", Catra answered with a weird smirk that did something to her. "I'm not a very patient person, so before I wait another three months: Wanna go out sometime?"

All she could do was stare. Whenever she tried to get words out, her mouth just opened and closed like a fish, while somewhere in the back of her mind, she was cheering. "Like a date?" She was an idiot.

Luckily, the other laughed and didn't take back the offer. "Yes, dummy", she said with a roll of her very pretty eyes — one of the biggest sources of distraction. "Unless I completely misread all the times you stare at me and the fact that you sit here for ten hours every day ordering six coffees even though you hate them."

"I don't hate them", she defended, but as bad a liar as she was, she knew that the dirty little chuckle meant that Catra didn't believe her. She sighed. "I'm not a big fan of coffee, this has nothing to do with your ability to make them."

"I know." The confidence was something that only made her more attractive. "So, do I get an answer before my break ends?", she got them back on topic.

"Oh, yes!", she blurted out, earning some glances from the few other people around. "I'd love to go out with you."

"Great", Catra replied and smiled. She had a cute smile. "Do I also get your number?", she then asked and held out her phone.

Adora almost threw her coffee, as well as her laptop, to the ground as she hurriedly reached over to take the phone. Somehow, she managed to evade the disaster, quickly grabbing the things before they could descend to the ground, and it highly amused Catra. She had a nice laugh, too.

A bit more carefully, she took the offered phone and put down her number that she had memorized for some reason.

With a quick wink, Catra left her table again, but Adora received a kiss emoji just a minute later from an unknown number. The rest of Catra's shift, Adora was a blushing mess, knowing that they had a date.

She didn't get any more work done that day, even after the woman's shift had ended, which was a few hours before the shop closed. All she could do was sit there, processing.

At some point, she couldn't evade the thought of her parents anymore. They definitely had expectations when it came to who she would choose as a partner — they were chill about the lesbian thing, but they would still hold her partner to the same old dumb standards. And she decided she didn't care.

Catra could have a tattoo and it wouldn't matter. If she had a shaved head, that would be cool. Hell, she could have been in jail and she wouldn't give a damn. Catra could be plotting to kill her for all she cared and she would probably think it's cute.

Adora was too far gone already, too deep into her feelings, especially now that Catra confirmed that the feeling was mutual. She was determined to have a great date and if they hit it off, she hoped it would last. Regardless of what anyone had to say.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, and I hope you liked it!! The second chapter will be posted tomorrow, hopefully, or Friday, should it turn out I underestimate just how busy tomorrow will be.

In the meantime, feel free to leave a comment, or a kudos, any constructive criticism, should you have it, or nothing. But at least drink some water (or any other refreshing liquid), yeah? Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Chapter 2!!!

I don't have much to say, so just have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had been stuck in a routine she hated. At least she had a proper job now, rehearsing for a show that was to premiere in just a month, but the rest of her life was devolving into a circle of hell.

When she came home, Adora might be there, maybe not. Who knew? Even if she was there, she really wasn't.

She tried her best to make it nice for them, cooking dinner and preparing a movie, but in all honesty, she didn't know why she still did it. She couldn't even remember the last time they had eaten dinner together.

Adora was either out with oh so important people, or holed up in her office writing. And Catra understood that, she really did. Writing was important to the blonde, and it was how she earned money. But was it too much to ask to eat together? To spend some time together at all?

At least she was still acknowledged. Adora would smile when she knocked on the doorframe and told her she was home, or that dinner was ready. They would cuddle in their sleep, they would kiss goodbye in the morning.

They didn't talk, though. Not much anyway.

Catra still tried to make time to go to those terrible parties and gatherings. Usually, she was abandoned after five minutes. Then she would sit down by the bar and get so drunk that Adora had to

literally carry her outside. It wasn't a nice cycle she had gotten herself into, but she had nothing else to do but drink. It kind of came naturally.

And at least the bartender talked to her. It was usually the same one every time, went by DT and was really fun to be around, even gave her their own insight into her crippling relationship — their words, not hers.

Adora's weird new friends didn't even know her name, DT did. Whenever she was noticed by one of these jerks, their first question was always "You're Adora's wife, right?", followed up with "You must be so proud."

She was. She really was. Catra loved to see the other glow when talking about her books and her progress, loved how she smiled in excitement when she tried not to give away a plot twist when pitching her work. Hell, she even loved to watch her write and get frustrated and pace and sit back down, delete, rewrite. She had kept every single review of every book that Adora had written that she could find.

Of course, she was proud…

She just didn't like being abandoned and forgotten, forced to entertain the bartender. Again, they were cool, but she would rather hang out with her wife.

They were at another one of these things. Over the last couple of months, with rehearsal, she had declined more and more often if it was too far away. This had been at least just a short car ride.

"You should get to bed soon, kitten", DT reminded her, and she glanced at the clock.

It was late and she had another rehearsal tomorrow. If they didn't leave within the next ten minutes, she would be too tired and Spinerella would give her that unsettling, disappointed look. The woman was never angry, just motherly disappointed and Catra

couldn't deal with that. Even worse if Netossa would be there to bring over some lunch again.

She really couldn't believe that she somehow managed to have her new boss be her old boss's wife.

"Thanks", she mumbled a bit slurred — she had refrained from drinking as much as she could, unwilling to risk being hungover, but she just couldn't say no to a couple of drinks when DT made them so well.

She got up from the bar and tried to find Adora, but couldn't spot her anywhere. DT sighed and pointed towards a little crowd forming around a blonde. That would be Adora.

"Excuse me", she grumbled as she elbowed her way through. Only a few people complained, but they were loud.

"Catra?", Adora asked, confusedly, when she spotted her. "What's wrong?"

"We need to go, it's late", was all she said. The other knew her schedule and she didn't need to disclose anything in front of strangers. It was bad enough that she spilled her heart to the bartender all the time.

The crowd now stared at Adora expectantly, Catra noticed, and somehow she knew how this was going to end. "Uh, why don't you go home already? I need to take care of a few more things." The blonde smiled and it calmed her enough to not completely lose it in front of everyone. With the press present.

"Kay", was all she said because she had learned a long time ago that fighting this was useless anyway.

She went back over to DT and asked them to call a taxi for her.

"Why do you keep coming?", they asked after that was done.

Catra had rested her head on the counter and didn't even bother to look up. "What are you talking about?", she grumbled and, miraculously, the other heard her over the music.

"You hate it here, you get drunk every time and I'm sure you have better ways to spend the night", they told her. "With people who actually care about you."

Now she did look up. "Adora does care about me", she all but growled.

They only raised a perfectly styled eyebrow. "Yeah? Then why are you not going home together?" She only glared in response and they sighed. "Look, kitten, I think this entire thing is already over, but you obviously don't believe that. Put that faith to good use and talk to her before you cross a line and end up miserable forever."

She knew they were right, but she just didn't have time to talk about her feelings right now. Adora obviously didn't have time to listen, either. But her birthday was coming up shortly before the start of the show. Maybe, they would have some time then.

"Wanna come to my show?", she asked instead of answering.

Their eyes lit up immediately. "Yes!", was the overly enthusiastic answer. "Oh, do I get VIP? Can I go backstage? I love the theater!"

"Probably not, sorry", she told them. "But I can get you a ticket and…" She lowered her voice, thinking about it again. "Actually, maybe I can smuggle you backstage."

A squeal escaped them, and then they pulled out their phone to check availability. Turns out, they were *busy*, so eventually they made a spontaneous call to cancel on someone just to be able to come to the premiere.

She knew a few tickets were still there. The sale had only started a month ago, so she herself made a call to Frosta, their producer,

though she got involved with everything, being a little control freak. And she was young enough to be cool about Catra reserving a really nice and expensive seat for someone she would barely call a friend.

They also gave her their number, so they could text and figure out how to smuggle them backstage.

Once that was done, they extended the kindness of seeing her outside and into the taxi, waving until she was down the street.

It was a short and quiet ride and at home, she quickly went to bed.

The next morning, she noticed that Adora hadn't come home. She did receive a text at three in the morning, though, telling her that she had lost track of time and would stay in a hotel overnight, but would be home later.

Catra sat in bed and did that breathing thing that Perfuma had taught her, before getting ready for work.

Rehearsal was as exhausting as always, but she had successfully avoided disappointed looks, hit all her notes and steps, even got a bit of praise, and was able to think of something other than her relationship problems for a few hours.

Before she got home, she gave Frosta the money for the seat she had reserved and received a ticket in return, both physically as well as the online access. She forwarded that to DT, who sent back an army of emojis, all happy, excited, and celebrating. At least someone was happy.

Then she finally went home. The car was in front of the building and relief flooded her that Adora had kept her word. She went inside and peered into the office, knocking gently on the doorframe. "Hey, Adora."

"Hi", was the curt answer as swift fingers typed away on the laptop.

Keep it cool, she told herself. "How was the rest of the party?"

Adora looked up. That was something. She even smiled. "It was nice. It's a shame you had to go so early, it got really fun later."

She hummed and doubted it internally. Before, when she had stayed longer and gotten extremely drunk every week, Adora had claimed the same thing the next day, every time. Meanwhile, Catra had never been more bored in her life, every time. "Yeah, well, rehearsal was important."

"I know, it's fine. There's always next time", the other said and went back to writing.

But DT was right. Why did she keep coming to these things? "Actually", she said then, making a decision. "I really need to focus right now. I don't have that much time anymore and honestly… you don't need me there. I'm always just sitting by the bar, doing nothing."

"Oh…" Her fingers slowed for a second. "Well, that's okay. You don't have to come." She kept writing.

While Catra really didn't want to go to any more parties where she was ignored and bored and quite frankly wasting her life, and while it was true that she needed to focus on her own job, she had somehow thought that Adora would do … something. Not particularly fight her, but at least inquire a bit more about it, ask how she felt. Anything.

"I'll get dinner started", she said because she needed to get out of this room.

"Yep."

Great, now she was getting ignored in her own home. It wasn't a new development, but it still hurt.

In an impulsive moment, and because she decidedly wasn't drunk enough for this, she took a bottle of wine they had for some

reason — probably an extremely old gift from Glimmer, at least from last year, since Adora's friends got just as neglected as her wife — and poured herself a glass.

***

Adora only noticed she was blocking the walkway when people repeatedly bumped into her. She moved out of the way quickly, luckily finding a bench because she really needed to sit down to process.

She had just received a call from a publisher, she had sent her book to. It had been an unknown number and she had been in the middle of the street when she fished out the phone and took the call with confusion. Never in her wildest dreams would she have expected the news that was delivered to her.

After months and months of writing and rewriting and editing and her parents urging her to find something better and Catra encouraging her to keep going, she finally did it. Her book was getting published.

A giggle escaped her at the absurd thought. Her book was really getting published. Was it real? It didn't feel like it, but it must be. She never dreamed of receiving this call while sitting next to a more than full trashcan.

Not that she cared about that right now. This was truly too good to be true, and yet it was really happening. Everyone always told her that she could be lucky if she even found anyone willing to give her manuscript a semblance of a chance — which made sense since she was young and debut novels were often overlooked — but now, she not only would get her book published, no the publisher also told her they would love to take a look at any future work, too.

She had a foot in the door. This usually didn't happen so quickly — that was why her parents were so skeptical — but it somehow happened to her. And it paid pretty well, too.

Adora has never felt so happy in her life. Not just because of the publisher, but because of the best girlfriend she could have asked for, that she was about to move in with.

Speaking of, she had actually been on her way to check out an apartment for them. She took a deep breath and collected herself again. It was still early, as she had been trying not to be too late and may have overdone that a little, so even though she got sidetracked for a second, she should still be on time.

With her phone still in hand, she was tempted to call Catra, but she was currently at an audition and Adora didn't want to destroy the other's focus now. She could tell her later, and if the apartment turned out good, maybe she would even have two pieces of good news to share.

She arrived, still a good bit early, but the landlord didn't seem to mind and led her inside. She seemed nice, a bit unbothered, but still miles better than Catra's current landlord.

The apartment itself was fine — a bit of love was definitely needed to pep up the place, but it was spacious and there was a little nook by the window for Adora's writing desk. The space in the living room could hardly be filled with furniture, which was good if Catra wanted to rehearse. It had a decent kitchen and a bright bedroom. And it was on the top floor in a corner, and the landlord told her the walls were decently thick, which meant noise complaints could be kept at a minimum — Catra's voice was lovely, in Adora's humble opinion, but that didn't mean everyone wanted to hear it at six in the morning.

As she stood in the empty bedroom, mentally already decorating it, her phone rang.

"Hey, Adora", Catra's voice rang through. "How's the apartment?", she asked, sounding a bit tired. Adora guessed the audition didn't go well then.

"Good", she answered the question instead of asking one of her own. "It's really nice, and checks all the boxes. It's a bit plain at the moment, but I don't think that'll be hard to fix with all your plants."

A sigh. "Sure. If they're not dead by then", she grumbled. "I really don't get why Perfuma keeps giving me plants when she knows they all die eventually."

She hummed. "She trusts you."

"I don't get that, either", Catra points out. "I hate to make her sad. Why can't she just stop? I honestly think the only reason I end up with these things is that Perfuma keeps buying them, and Scorpia then reminds her that they have no space. I mean, have you been to their place? It's like a botanical garden."

Adora couldn't help but chuckle. "We're back on that conspiracy?"

"It's not a conspiracy. That woman is obsessed and I am this close to hosting an intervention", the other groaned. It was cute, honestly.

"I'll draw the posters if you want", she offered with a grin. She honestly would paint a banner if Catra asked her to.

Another sigh. "No, before we spend money on that, let's try to give these bitches a better living environment first. So, the apartment is good? Are we gonna take it?"

"We don't have many other options, and out of all of them, this is still the best", she said. "Do you want pictures?"

She heard a snort. "I can't really look at them right now and I don't know how long you want to stick around there", she pointed

out. "I trust you. You say it's nice, it's nice. Make an offer before it's gone."

"Are you sure?", she asked, not really wanting to make a decision without the other and while Catra did give her consent, it wasn't like she had actually seen the place.

"I'm sure." Adora could almost hear the eye roll. "Hurry up, before we're homeless."

She laughed. "We wouldn't be. I'm sure my parents would love to have us until we find something else."

"Yeah, I'd rather be homeless." It didn't even sound like a joke. Catra meant that.

Her parents didn't hate Catra, but as expected, they hadn't loved her, either. They tried to be nice, but the entire meeting had been rather cold. They clearly disapproved of Catra's job, ambitions, friends and living situation. She hadn't said much about her past and that, too, did Adora's parent not approve of.

At least they didn't try to convince her to break up with the woman.

Adora had to admit, living under these circumstances was not something she looked forward to, either. "I'll talk to the landlord then", she said after her brief consideration.

"Cool. See you at my place? I still need help packing", Catra reminded her.

"I'll be there", she promised. Soon after, the call ended because Adora was urged to hurry up and she was also a bit worried about Catra being run over — being on the phone was distracting after all.

She looked for the landlord then, who had left her pretty much to her own devices, and had vanished somewhere.

In the end, her girlfriend was right, they needed a place to live and going back to her parents wasn't an enticing option for either of them.

So far, they had somehow made it work for them both to stay at Catra's place — officially, Adora still lived with her parents, but she started to spend more and more nights away from them, so that she really didn't live with them anymore.

There were several problems with that arrangement, though. For one, it was a one-room apartment and very tight for two people. It was also very run-down and, in her opinion, not a suitable place to live for anything that breathed. And lastly, Catra was kind of getting thrown out.

Officially, it was the constant noise complaints, but because the landlord didn't give a shit about anything, he never really cared, so while it stated that on paper, Adora doubted it was the real reason. More likely, and she knew that thanks to Glimmer's mom, the building was finally recognized as a health hazard by the town and was supposed to be demolished and rebuilt.

In either case, they needed something new. So, Adora hunted down the landlord, who at least seemed to care enough to keep the place in good shape, even if it apparently was impossible to get a hold of her.

Telling her that they were interested and getting a contract on hand was surprisingly easy, which once again made her question whether her life was real.

After that was done, she went through the horrors of public transport to get to the other side of town, to where Catra's apartment was. When she arrived, the woman happily opened the door and handed her the tape before Adora even set foot in the room.

She rolled her eyes, but smiled all the same. "No small talk, then?", she asked, but did tape the nearest box closed.

Catra eyed her suspiciously and sat down on the bed, the only real place to sit in the entire room. "What do you want to talk about?"

"Well, we got a new apartment, for one", she reminded and smiled proudly, even though she hadn't even really had to fight for it.

"Yeah, I already knew that", Catra then said with a smirk. "There's no way you would have gone back to your parents and you did seem to like it." She really knew her too well. "And for two?"

Here goes. "I got a call earlier. From a publisher I sent my manuscript to and … they said they would publish it", she announced, slightly awkward, still with tape in hand.

Catra stared wide-eyed, processing and Adora thought that's what she must have looked like earlier. Then the other suddenly stood up and hugged her tightly. "That's great! I'd pop open a bottle, but sadly, I cannot afford that. I can only offer you the weird health concoction that Perfuma put together." She walked over to the fridge and pulled out a bottle of… something.

"Uh, maybe not", Adora mumbled, staring at the slightly muddy-looking liquid. Was that even liquid?

"Smart choice", the other snorted and put it back. "I am happy for you, though", she said and walked over. "I always knew you were a brilliant writer."

They kissed then, and it was better than champagne could have been. After that, they may or may not have found other ways to celebrate instead of packing boxes.

***

Catra was riding a high. Recently married and newly cast in an actual theater production.

About a week after getting back from the honeymoon, she got a call from one of the many, *many* auditions she had gone to — she couldn't even remember what she had auditioned for, and hoped that they would offhandedly mention it, which they luckily did. And it was a … well, it wasn't big, big, but definitely big for her first real job, and big enough to maybe hopefully get her somewhere!

That day, she had run into Adora's office, startling the woman enough to make her fall off her chair, and told her the news. Her wife — she would never get tired of saying that — had been as excited as she had hoped her to be. They went to a really fancy restaurant and had a lot of fun.

It was slightly disappointing then that Adora went to work again early the next day.

It was fine. Catra had to do a bit of work herself to get into shape. The first rehearsal started in just a few weeks, and considering how terrible her outlook had been, she hadn't exactly kept up with a workout routine.

When the first rehearsal came around, she had never felt better — not just because she had moved her muscles again, but because finally, there was some hope in her life.

She told Adora everything over dinner. Their choreographer, Spinerella, was kind but strict, and coincidentally married to her old boss. Her stage partner, Sea Hawk, was overly dramatic and kept getting into songs about some girl named Mermista, who she assumed to be his girlfriend or stalking victim. And that their technician, Entrapta, was a bit too excited about her job and blew up the sound equipment twice on the first day. Catra also wasn't completely alone around strangers since Scorpia somehow managed to become part of the backstage crew.

Her wife listened and laughed and went to work right after.

Catra couldn't blame her for that. Adora was close to finishing the next book, which was important, and after all, she was around and listened and smiled and laughed and shared her excitement. The door to the office wasn't even closed.

Yet, she felt a bit lonely. Missing their first apartment, or even her old, rundown room. They had been closer then, physically, and she missed that. She hated not really seeing the other the entire day until they went to bed. But she couldn't ask that of Adora right now, not when she was so busy.

And Catra was, too. And things were good, still. To imagine that just four years ago, she was a lonely and depressed barista who still had nightmares like a little kid. And now she was married to a gorgeous, successful woman and things were finally starting to work out for her, too. She was starting to get successful, too.

It couldn't be more perfect. She really shouldn't complain.

***

When Catra came home, she fell headfirst into the couch with a loud groan. No 'hey', just pure frustration that their poor couch had to bear. Adora looked up from her laptop. "Tired?"

The other answered something, but it was unintelligible.

She chuckled. "I'm sorry, I'm afraid I don't speak cushion", she joked, walking over and crouching down in front of her girlfriend, who at least moved her head to the side to look at her.

"I said, if I have to discuss inflation one more time, I will scratch someone's eyeball out", she growled and sat up. "Five bucks for a grand?", she mimicked, with a high pitch. "Yes, Karen, that's not

my fault. What do they expect me to do? I don't control that shit! And I'm not giving out free discounts, I still need my job!"

Adora chuckled again. Catra always got angry rather quickly, which was terrifying as much as it was endearing. At least to her. "What about your audition this morning?" Another groan and Catra fell back onto the couch. "I'm guessing that didn't go better?"

"No", was the answer with a pout. "It's really hard to impress a bunch of gay people when two hundred girls went on before you", she grumbled and then sighed. "Maybe I should give up."

"But you love singing and acting", Adora protested. "I'm sure they'll see how talented and great you are. You are meant for great things, I know it."

Catra smiled, at least that was something, but it looked sad. "What good does talent do when I'm starving? Or end up in jail because I do eventually kill a customer? Maybe I should start looking for a job that actually pays well and… is nice enough, I guess."

She sighed. "Let me tell you a story."

"Adora", the other whined. "I love you. I love what you do, but I'm really tired."

"Just listen", she said and kissed her forehead before getting up. She always thought better when pacing. "It's a story about… a seamstress named… Castaspella."

Her girlfriend snorted. "You couldn't be any lazier?"

"Shush. A seamstress named Castaspella, who lived in this small town where everyone knew everyone, and she spent her whole life doing the practical things and sewing for everyone but herself", she kept going, her mind trying to make up things on the spot. She just hoped this would end up making sense. "One day, she was really old, she said to herself, 'If only I had a little more

time, I would sew a dress so godly and divine, the dress in my head, that every girl would fight over'."

"Uh-huh, how old is really old?", Catra asked. She always did that, trying to throw Adora off, though sometimes she had some good notes and ideas.

"Very", Adora responded. This wasn't a proper manuscript, after all, just a pep talk. She didn't need to get specific. "Which is why she gave up. She said, 'If only I had more time, but I have no more hours left.' Outside, it was dark already. The day was over, and her life was getting to a close, too."

"Yeah, I feel better already."

She ignored that. "But then, suddenly, the clock on the wall began to glow and said, 'No! Not yet. You'll get to be happy, I will give you unlimited time, so sew whatever your heart desires.' And Castaspella considered it, but decided that no, 'I've got to make do with the time I've got.' But the next night the clock did it again. It said, 'Don't go yet. Just make one stitch and see what you can do.' Again, Castaspella tells the clock, that no 'It's alright, I've accepted my fate', but this time, the clock didn't let go so easily. 'Just one single stitch, please just try. Don't give up on your dream.'"

A sigh left Catra. "I know what you're doing", she grumbled.

"Not done yet", she told her. "So, Castaspella reluctantly picked up her thread and did what she was told. She made one stitch and realized that it was possible. She made another and another and she cut out the pattern with precision. Nothing has ever gone so perfectly — not a single stitch wrong, not a single mistake, not a single bow misplaced. Time stopped for her and she worked and worked until it was done. Castaspella cried tears of joy. Her dream became reality, her dress was in front of her and she felt as young as she hadn't in a long time. Happy, youthful and accomplished."

"People not named after a magic potion don't have weird magic clocks, though", Catra pointed out.

Adora came back to crouch in front of her. "Yes, you do." She had meant to offer it a while ago, but knew how proud Catra was. This seemed like a good time, though. "I earn a lot. You don't necessarily need to work. You can go to auditions all day long until you find someone sensible, who sees you for the amazing person you are."

Catra looked shocked to say the least. "I can't do that", she said then, not very surprisingly. "What if something happens?"

"Like what?", Adora asked stupidly before the realization came to her a second later. "That won't happen", she corrected then. "I love you, always will. I promise I won't leave you alone. We'll be in this together. You've got my back, and I've got yours. You already did so much supporting me, I just want to support you, too."

The other sighed. "I'll think about it, okay?"

She nodded. That was more than fine.

It was only a day later that Catra impulsively quit her job after being blamed, once again, for the prices, the taste of the donuts and the weather. Adora had just laughed and kissed her and assured her that she had meant every word.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you liked it <333
As always, feedback of any kind is encouraged (just be nice about pls, thanks <3)

Until next time, probably Friday or Saturday... probably Saturday... Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Chapter three, whoo! (This one has the two vague Shadow Weaver mentions, btw, nothing big but I'm giving you a warning anyway <33)
>
> Also, I have restricted this fic to registered users only, which is not something I wanted to do, but... well, it seems that instead of Christmas elves, I've got trolls this year... I will admit that I was more amused by it than insulted, but it still doesn't mean I wanna deal with it, so I restricted access. Maybe I'll make it public again in the new year. You know, when people hopefully don't feel the need to make others miserable just because they're unhappy during the holiday season.
>
> On that note, I do hope that the stress, the family, or whatever else can go wrong about Christmas, doesn't get you down and you have a nice time <333
>
> Now, please have fun!! And like I said, I am not making Adora into a Jamie here, so I took a lot of creative liberties in her sections and I hope you like it <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were walking through the park, which they didn't do too often. It wasn't a lack of time preventing them — if they wanted to, they could make it happen — but slow and calm wasn't really their thing. Adora was chaotically addicted to her work, and Catra was too hot-tempered and impatient for anything even close to relaxing.

And yet they were holding hands, strolling lazily through the park and enjoying some fresh air. She didn't know why, though. Adora had just asked if she would like to take a walk and Catra had

agreed because she had started to get a headache looking at audition offers. Or even trying to find any.

It wasn't all bad, she thought. As exhausted as she was lately, she wasn't exactly itching to do something right now, which probably helped their little activity to actually become relaxing.

Eventually, they ended up overlooking the river from some pavilion in the middle of the park. It was a rather cold day, meaning only a few people dared to go outside, which was perfect.

"We could go to the museum", Adora then offered, sounding nervous for some reason. "Look at the dinosaurs. Maybe you'll get away with climbing one."

"I was five", Catra scoffed and bumped their shoulders together. "I never should have told you that."

"I'm glad you did", the other responded, looking out over the river. "I want to know everything there is about you. I didn't know you for the first 23 years, but I got to spend the last four with you, and I want to be with you for everything else, too." The woman took a deep breath and turned to fully face her. "I can't ask that much of you. So I'll only ask you to spend the next ten minutes with me. I think we can handle that. We could watch the waves, or the sky, or just sit and wait for the time to pass, and if we make it until then, can I ask you for another ten?

Suddenly, the blonde was on her knees, while Catra's heart dropped and she was sure it was down there with the woman. "Adora", she breathed out, not sure what to say.

"There are so many minutes I want to share with you", the woman said, pulling out a box from somewhere. "What do you say? We take it day by day until we grow old?", she then asked, that stupidly dorky smile on her face.

The "yes" was on the tip of her tongue, but she couldn't help but be snarky first. "You rehearsed that speech, didn't you?"

Adora luckily just laughed. "Maybe", she admitted. "You know I'm not good at public speaking."

"Not much of a public to behold", Catra pointed out. They were completely alone right now, after all. "Adora", she then sighed because some things still needed to be said. "I'm impatient and short-tempered, and we will fight. A lot. I will work on that, but you can't expect a miracle, I'm just a grumpy person overall, and why are you smiling?"

"Because I know that", the other told her with a shrug, still in proposing position. It looked more ridiculous the longer she held that pose. "And I love you for it."

"You say that now", she mumbled and knelt down too, just because she was starting to feel awkward about looking down on the other. "You'll get sick of me eventually and when that happens… we don't have to make it more expensive than necessary."

"Always so pragmatic", Adora sighed.

"One of us has to be", she defended with a roll of her eyes.

The blonde carefully placed the box on the ground and took her hands. "Catra, I love you. I've loved you from the moment I first saw you and I've loved you for four years, through every fight and every rough patch. And I will love you for a very, *very* long time to come. I'll love you even when I'm sitting somewhere in a rocking chair, delusional and old and you are gone. I'll drive whoever will have to take care of me mad, that's how much I'll talk about you."

"Who says you'll get to outlive me? Why do I die before you?", Catra asked because she felt somewhat offended, ignoring the blush creeping to her face.

Adora once again just laughed. "I'll never get sick of you. I just hope you don't get sick of me, either."

This time, she laughed, too. "Do you promise?"

"I promise", the other answered easily with a soft smile. Catra went ahead and kissed her then, even though she hadn't actually given an answer yet. "Does this mean yes?"

"For the next ten minutes", she answered with a smirk, kissing her favorite idiot again. "And every ten minutes I have."

***

Adora wasn't sure if being married had anything to do with it, but things started to pick up more for some reason after the wedding. If she had been successful before, she was almost famous now.

It seemed more people discovered her books — something about TikTok? — and her publisher was happy about that, but it also meant more work for her. More pressure to write the next book and more events lined up.

She didn't hate it by any means, but the constant gathering, on top of being holed up in her office, trying to get the creativity going, was really taking a toll on her. And then there was Catra, who she did not nearly have as much time for as she would like.

Whenever she could, she did spend her moments with her wife — like listening to her at dinner, and … getting ready in the morning — it was decidedly too little.

She did have a lot of fun introducing her to everyone as her wife, though. Most of the time, Catra excused herself quickly and left her alone, then she tended to sit by the bar and talk to whoever was handing out drinks. At least she seemed to have fun, a lot more than in a crowd of people who only talked business.

That was fine. As long as Catra was comfortable, everything was fine. Still, she couldn't help but look over. Whenever their eyes

met, she made sure to smile brightly. The brunette usually smiled back, but it mostly looked tired and bored.

Adora didn't know what to do. She couldn't just leave, but she also didn't want Catra to spend hours all alone and bored.

When the woman finally got a job, she started urging to go home earlier, and Adora wanted nothing but to make that wish come true, but with everyone wanting to talk to her, it would be rude to go home that early. The least she could do was let Catra take a cab without having to worry about her. The woman did need to sleep, after all, to be rested for rehearsal, so it was probably what she wanted.

Adora certainly wouldn't force her to stay, especially since she was so obviously bored.

It was fine. They would be fine. She just had to make a bit more time. Then again, Catra was gone for most of the day, and they did already spent what little time they had together. When was she supposed to make more time?

This was terrible. Neither of them could just throw all their work to the side, but she really wanted to have more time with her wife.

Maybe when things calmed down again, they could do more together. They could even take a nice vacation away from it all. Right now, this was a lost battle. She would just wait a little.

That sounded like a plan. Once her publisher calmed down and Catra's show was done, they would have a chance to spend more time together, and then they would be fine.

Until then, she would just work extra hard to get this done and over with. So that she'll actually have time when Catra does too.

***

Catra took in air and started to sing. She noticed at the first note that she was off. She tried to fix it quickly and power through, but as expected, she was told to get out before she even got halfway through the song.

They said it more politely, of course, but the message was the same — you suck, get out of here before you destroy our ears.

She hated this, and during her walk of shame through the still packed hallway, she debated once again if she should give up and get a job in politics — the degree that could possibly actually make her money.

No, Adora had encouraged her to do this, kind of made it possible even, and she would be damned if she couldn't even get one job offer. Just one, so she could stop lying on her resume.

That didn't mean she had to pretend to enjoy this process, though. Waking up at six every single day just to stand in line for five hours or more with a bunch of other girls and women, who were younger and prettier and obviously went to the gym and already have a perfect resume because they didn't waste years in college and actually cared enough to take part in dumb high school productions.

She could hear them belt out their little hearts through the closed door and already knew it wouldn't be her walking out with a job offer today.

When it was finally her turn, way after noon, her stomach growled because she hadn't had lunch because performing on a full stomach was terrible. Just as terrible as having to walk into a room with a bunch of men — always men — who judge everything. Her voice, her smile, her shoes, why are they always looking at her shoes?!

Catra knew she could sing. She knew she was good, and attractive, and all these other little things one needed to be at least noticed. But the entire thing made her so nervous that, even if they were intrigued by her, she messed up enough on the singing to be brushed aside.

She also knew that she would be less frightened on an actual stage. In college, she had managed to get cast in a hilariously small production, so she knew that under normal circumstances, she wouldn't be able to see the audience. But for these things, she was able to clearly see the stares of five guys who were judging her.

So yeah, she was nervous. Especially when not even the pianist could hit the right notes. How was she supposed to do anything?

They always looked so bored, too. She supposed it made sense when they spent their entire day hearing the same song from hundreds of women. And of course, they would also always go through her resume in front of her, half of which was a blatant lie… *at least* half, maybe even more. But she had to fill in the gaps somehow.

She wanted to go home, but she couldn't do that either because Adora needed space to write. The blonde hadn't actually said anything of the sort, but Catra felt bad for being there constantly when she shouldn't be. She should be out half the day working, but she didn't have a job anymore, and apparently, she also wasn't getting one.

Her part-time barista job had been awful, but at least it had been steady and she felt less like a burden. Now, when her days were not crammed with auditions, she was home, and because she was considerate and curious, she asked Adora about progress, which was how she knew that the blonde was working more slowly on the days she spent busying herself at the apartment.

Catra was a terrible girlfriend. She just needed one job to prove that she's worth working with, that she's not a screw-up.

Great, as if her thoughts weren't already depressing enough, her stepmom once again made it into her head, making her lose the lyrics and the melody and-

"Thank you", a voice cut through. "We'll call."

They won't. They never do. "Thank you", she answered, trying to sound sweet and not like she was about to murder someone or have a mental breakdown. The least she can do is not sully her reputation, as little of it as she had. If word got around that she was aggressive, her career would be over before she even managed to have one.

She breathed deeply once she was outside and no one stared her down. Another failed audition. That would be the fifth just this week.

Another breath, slowly devolving into one of Perfuma's breathing exercises. She couldn't let her stepmom get to her, not after years of therapy and progress. Adora. That she could think about.

Adora believed in her. So did Scorpia and Perfuma. Even Glimmer and Bow have been weirdly supportive lately. Maybe Catra should start believing, too. Maybe that would help with her nervousness and spiraling thoughts on stage. Maybe a bit of confidence would do the trick.

And maybe she should learn to stare anywhere but the weird guys staring at her dumb shoes. She hated those things. Maybe she should just wear different shoes. Maybe that would help too.

She really had to relax.

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Adora was home less and less. She was painfully aware of that, and she also knew that it bothered Catra, even though she never said anything.

Instead of calming down, as she had hoped, her publisher blew up her calendar to the point that it wasn't a proper option anymore to go home. That's how tight her schedule was. And whatever meeting, event, gathering, or other things that would come up, were never even anywhere close to home.

They called every day, at least. Well, most days. Catra was busy and exhausted, rehearsals really drained her, though she sounded content with that from what Adora could tell.

Their calls got shorter every time, too. Catra's exhaustion turned into frustrated silence, and no matter what the question was, the woman responded curtly. Adora tried to awaken some enthusiasm by asking about her production, but the answer was usually just "You know… same old." Like nothing new or funny happened anymore behind the scenes.

To be completely fair, she wasn't much better herself. Though in her case, everything *was* the boring same old story. The same people, the same conversations. Sometimes she debated just cancelling, but then she was reminded how important it was to make these connections.

"Are you home next week?" A usual question. Probably the one question Catra would ask the most.

"I can try", Adora said. "I don't think I have much planned for once. Maybe we can do something nice?"

"Yeah", Catra mumbled. "That'd be nice." It sounded tired and deflated, like she didn't believe it would actually happen. Had her wife lost this much faith in her?

She checked her calendar just to be sure she didn't mix something up, but she was pretty sure the next week was surprisingly free. A gasp escaped her when she noticed why that was. "It's your

birthday", she realized with shock. She had specifically requested that week to be free. "I'll be there, definitely!"

"Okay."

Adora waited a few seconds, but that was it. Nothing more. Did Catra not care? Didn't she want her to be there? "Do you already have plans?", she asked. Maybe that was it — her friends might have already invited her and she wanted to spend the day with them.

"No", the other said, though. Then there was a sigh. "It's fine. I know you're busy."

She frowned. "I'll be there", she said again.

"Okay." Again, that was it. No joy, no desire to plan something together. Nothing.

"Okay", she mirrored then. What else was she supposed to say when it was clear that Catra didn't believe her anyway? "Goodnight, Catra. Sleep well. I love you."

"You too." The line went silent. Just like that.

Adora let the phone drop with a sigh. Catra had been doing that a lot lately. She didn't say it back anymore, just halfheartedly said something in response that could refer to anything and nothing at once.

She had to fix this somehow, but she had no idea how. At least she was lucky to have nothing happen next week. That would be as good a start as any. They could spend Catra's birthday together, and if Adora was really lucky and her publisher granted her some grace, she could even see her show.

Did she even have tickets?

Adora had been in the process of getting comfortable when she sat up straight with another shock. She didn't have a ticket!

She scrambled to pull her laptop onto her lap, praying to any deity that would listen that there were still some tickets left.

The website was loading at a glacial pace and she almost screamed with the panic overcoming her.

For months, she had been meaning to do this. Catra had offered to talk to the venue and reserve something for her, but Adora had insisted on doing it the proper way. Between all these dumb parties and meetings, she must have forgotten.

Turns out, luck was on her side as she spotted a few empty seats. She let out a sigh of relief and sent some thank yous to the heavens before she took a look at them. None of the options were ideal and her view would be greatly obstructed, but she didn't care as she quickly selected the best one and moved to check out.

And if she had to sit on someone's lap, she would be there. She had to be there.

Adora really wasn't a religious person, but as the "Thank you for your purchase" lit up on the screen, she once again sent out a prayer to please let her have this one free week.

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The window was open a bit and she enjoyed the slight breeze in her hair as they drove. It was the only enjoyable part about this because they were on their way to Adora's parents, an encounter that Catra greatly dreaded.

The blonde hadn't exactly hyped them up to her, throwing around warnings and an etiquette manual instead, leaving Catra with more than just the expected anxiety of meeting the parents. And she was all too aware of her thrifted clothes that had a few food

stains on them that she had tried to hide with a worn-out leather jacket.

Adora had assured her that she looked hot, but it didn't quell any of her insecurities. She just didn't do well with parents. Not even her own. A fact that she had told the other when she had asked if she was ever going to meet Catra's parents. She had straight-up laughed in her face then, before explaining the no-contact thing briefly.

The blonde in all her softness at least tried to distract her by asking questions, mostly about the little gaps in her life.

Catra knew she wasn't a very open person when it came to her past before college, so the questions were naturally aimed there, though Adora kept them surface-level enough to make them easily answered.

It was sweet, she thought. Especially considering all her other attempts at dating felt like they were trying to tear her walls down with a sledgehammer.

These questions were things like how she found out she was a lesbian or — though carefully added — how her parents had reacted. If she had friends growing up, or any funny stories she was willing to tell.

Her answers were mostly short because her life, while sad, was not as eventful as others might think.

She found out because men disgusted her and women were hot, easy as that. Her parents didn't know, partly because they were dead, partly because she wasn't close enough with them to care if they knew, and partly because she didn't want to risk getting disowned and thrown out by her stepmom without a high school graduation in hand.

Her only friend for pretty much all of school and beyond was Scorpia. The only funny story she could think of to tell there was that the other has had a crush on her for years, and Catra's dumb

ass hadn't even noticed until her friend started to date Perfuma and suddenly all the awkwardness and anxiety around Catra was gone.

"There's not much to tell", she groaned eventually after another question about what happened during some part of her life. "High school was boring." It wasn't even a lie. She had spent her time studying and doing as many extracurriculars as she could to avoid going home. She didn't have much of a life at all back then.

"Oh, come on. There has to have been something exciting in your life", Adora said, rolling her eyes. "Any terrible breakups?", she then poked.

Catra thought for a second. There weren't a lot of relationships to cry home about. A short fling in summer camp that ended when summer did, a few hookups in her senior year with some girls who wanted to experiment, a couple of dates that led nowhere. The only real relationship she has had before Adora was at the start of college.

"There was this chick in one of my politics classes. Kept bothering me until I agreed to go out with her", she said then, remembering with disdain how that woman just couldn't take no for an answer.

"Wow, red flag", Adora agreed, sending her a side eye.

"Watch the road", she scolded, even though she knew how much of a rule stickler the blonde was. There was no way they would crash. "Well, yeah, but I guess she was cute, and she was pretty sweet and good in bed", she defended herself with a shrug. "Still one of the top ten worst years of my life."

"You endured this for one year?", the other exclaimed in shock.

"You don't get to judge", she said, remembering the couple of stories she had about Adora's exes, which were not just plenty but quite honestly embarrassing. Not even in any way unhealthy, just kind of humiliating for both parties if you asked Catra. "Anyway, so at some point, I honestly started to think about making this

work. Proper relationship and all that. She told me she had to focus on her career. I received a Post-it note telling me that all her stuff was gone from my place."

"Ouch", Adora laughed. "You can do better than that."

"Yeah, I know", she agreed. "Am I?"

The blonde looked over a few times, probably making sure that Catra really was talking about her. Maybe even trying to figure out what she was talking about at all. She just wanted to find out where Adora was at, with all of this.

"I mean, I definitely won't leave you a Post-it note. That's even worse than breaking up over text, but I'm … I'm not perfect either."

"No", she chuckled in agreement. "You can be pretty annoying, and you're a perfectionist and a people pleaser on top, and-"

"Okay, chill", Adora interrupted. "I know I have issues, but my point was… I'm not freaking out. I'm ready for a proper relationship. If that's what you want."

She nodded. They have been dating for a few months now, and Catra has admittedly thought about this a lot. Them. She realized she wanted this more than she had ever wanted anything. "I don't need any lifetime commitments. And I don't need you to change anything about yourself. But I do want you. I don't know why or how that happened, but you're really important to me."

Adora smiled. "I love you, too."

They hadn't exactly said that yet. There had been some close calls on both sides, starting to say it and then quickly making up something else, or saying anything close enough but not quite it yet.

It left her in shock for a few seconds before making up her mind. She hadn't been sure before if she really wanted to ask, but now

she just had to. "So, I'm getting thrown out of my apartment."

Adora swerved slightly when her head whipped around to stare at her in shock before she quickly remembered where they were and looked back to the street. "What?", she then asked.

Catra laughed nervously, considering the near-death experience just now. Maybe she shouldn't have led with that. "Relax, I can find something new. That wasn't the point", she tried to calm the other, who nodded, slowly releasing a breath. "I was asking if you wanted to move in with me."

The blonde swerved once more when she again tried to stare in shock and forgot she was driving a death machine. Apparently, it wouldn't have mattered what she had started with.

"Should I drive?", she offered since the other clearly had some things to process.

"No. I mean yes- no." Adora took a deep breath. "I can drive. And I'd love to move in with you. I practically live at your place already anyway."

"Really?" It was the answer she had hoped for, but still hadn't dared to expect. It was one thing to be able to drop in and out, and another to sign a contract with her. So much for no lifetime commitments. "There's no pressure. We can take it slow." She didn't want the other to feel forced into this.

A hand reached hers. "Catra, you're not very patient, remember?", she teased. "I want to officially move in with you. Because I love you."

She smiled. "I love you, too", she said it back then, and the squeeze on her hand meant absolutely everything to her.

With Adora by her side, she could deal with parents. She could deal with everything as long as they were together.

Chapter End Notes

The last chapter will probably be out tomorrow, so I won't have to leave you waiting over Christmas <333

Until then, stay hydrated and don't let yourself get stressed out <33

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

We have made it to the end! And back to the present!

This one had no time jumps anymore, just the conclusion with Adora trying to fix things.
I hope you like it <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had not gotten another flight. Hadn't even looked. The first night, she just sulked, which didn't feel very productive, but she had to get it out somehow.

The next day, she had called her publisher and told whoever answered that she had missed her flight by some great misfortune of the traffic — she was not going to tell anyone about her relationship problems. The last thing she or Catra needed was for anyone to leak it to the press. Neither of them was big enough for it to really be a problem, but she still didn't want that floating on the internet. Especially when Catra did make it big eventually.

She later received an email from her publisher and they were pissed to say the least, telling her how many great opportunities she would miss, but the only opportunity Adora was interested in right now was a chance to make things right with her wife.

The rest of that day and the following two, she spent in her hotel room, not leaving it once, to make up a battle plan.

On day three, she was momentarily distracted when her phone was bombarded with calls and texts from Bow and Glimmer alike. She didn't answer even one, knowing what they would talk about — while Glimmer and Catra hadn't exactly hit it off at the beginning, they had gotten weirdly close, and judging from the

text messages, her friend knew something and would yell at her about it, undoubtedly coming to Catra's defense.

While Adora didn't have the mental capacity to deal with that or the soft kindness that Bow would bring to the table, she was, at the very least, glad that Catra had people to come to her aid and defend her. But as much as she possibly needed support, too, she had to put her entire brain power into coming up with ideas.

Catra's show was tonight, and she still had her ticket. She would go, of course, and somehow try to talk to the other afterwards, though she still hadn't quite figured out the details yet.

The more pressing problem was that she had nothing to wear. Technically, she wouldn't care if she went there in a potato sack if she only could manage to find the words in the moment, but sadly, after three days with no change of clothes, she smelled terribly.

So, she took a quick shower and sprayed her shirt with a heavy dose of deodorant before heading downstairs and outside. The hotel was in the middle of the city and finding any shop that sold nice enough clothes wasn't hard. Though she was looked at weirdly by everyone.

Once she had a couple of sets of clothing, she headed straight back into her hotel room.

Now that this was done, back to the plan. She would go to the show, which was good, but not good enough if Catra didn't know she would be there. Since she had insisted on doing things the proper way, she also had no VIP access or anything, but she figured it wouldn't be too hard to find the stage door and wait there. Hopefully, security wouldn't think she's some weirdo.

Then, assuming Catra wouldn't yell at her the second she saw her, she would talk to her and tell her that she was sorry and that she wanted to be better. After that, she could only hope that Catra would give her another chance.

Sinking down on the bed, she wondered how she had let it get this bad to begin with.

If she was being honest with herself, she had noticed a long time ago that Catra didn't feel satisfied, that she was distancing herself and made excuses. But Adora found excuses, too. That the other was just tired, exhausted from rehearsal, they both had work to do — somehow she always made herself believe that they would be fine, that they would make it a bit longer, and that they could do more once things calmed down.

She had thought she had a bit of calm, a free week, before she got that call, telling her how important it was to come and Adora thought Catra didn't care anyway. She certainly hadn't sounded excited to spend time with her.

Her wife had looked happy, though, when they had seen each other in that park. And she had started the conversation by saying they could try again.

Adora really hoped the other still believed that.

Even if she didn't and Catra wanted that divorce, she wouldn't just abandon the woman. She had made a vow and before that a promise that she would have the other's back and she would continue to do that for as long as it was necessary, even if Catra never wanted to see her again.

Since she had nothing to do, she tried to create at least a rough outline of things she wanted to say and should definitely mention. She did that and tried to memorize it until her phone vibrated with a reminder that she should get ready.

She took another shower, put on her new clothes that felt uncomfortably stiff, readied her ticket on her phone and took a deep breath. Then she went downstairs again and she swore the receptionist sighed with relief that she wore fresh and non-smelly clothes.

Adora ignored that and instead debated whether she should take the car. But for one, it was a good walk away in front of their apartment, and two, parking in the city would be terrible, so she took the bus.

When she finally reached the theater, the line was already pretty long and she nervously kneaded the hem of her shirt as it slowly crept forward. With every passing minute, she got more anxious.

Catra had no reason to forgive her. She would yell at her and break up with her all over again. Her hope that her wife still wanted to try was steadily leaving her.

She startled and fumbled with her phone when a security guy was suddenly in front of her and asked her for her ticket. While she apologized profusely, he scanned her ticket without any problems, and then she was quickly ushered inside.

The theater was beautiful and she finally understood why Catra loved going to work here so much. The woman had gushed about how pretty and old everything was after her first day, but Adora hadn't really understood and obviously didn't bother to visit her here either.

Her seat was just as terrible as she had expected when she had bought it, crammed to the sidelines, barely able to see the stage and the angle obstructed anything that might be happening behind the column on her left. Not ideal, but she was here. That had to count for something, right?

The old lady who had settled down next to her sent her several annoyed glances as she nervously tapped her foot against the floor and bit her fingernails.

Why did you have to come to these things so early? Adora didn't want a glass of champagne or overpriced water, and she didn't want to mingle and talk about the weather either. Why couldn't everyone just find their seats and the show could start after ten

minutes? Was that so hard? Was being here an hour early really necessary?

She did invest in a playbill, though, so at least she had something to read for a few minutes, but she had no idea how to bridge the rest of the time. Originally, she only bought it to remember Catra's first role, but by the time the first warning rang through the theater, she had already read it a dozen times.

Before she had a chance to let herself spiral again, the last warning was heard and soon after, the lights finally went dark and the show started.

For the next two hours, Adora didn't think of her crumbling relationship. She was completely entranced by what was happening on stage.

Catra was brilliant. Everyone was. They were perfectly on point and on pitch — though Adora didn't know much about music — and Catra had great chemistry with her co-lead, who she assumed must be Sea Hawk. For how dramatic he had always been painted, he was still able to give a grounded performance.

Her eyes were glued to her wife, though, whenever she was on stage. She cried three times because Catra delivered her songs with so much emotional depth that Adora felt everything the character was going through. It hit her somewhere deep within her soul, and while she must have heard the woman practice at home, she never felt like this before. Even the annoyed lady next to her shed a few tears.

She had always known how talented Catra was, but seeing it realized like this was something she didn't want to miss — if she weren't so sure that everything was sold out, she would want to come again.

It hit her a few minutes later. She almost hadn't come at all.

When it was over, the crowd was loud with whistles and claps and shouts. They had been loud throughout the entire curtain call as a

whole, but when Catra stepped on stage to take her bow, the volume must have at least doubled.

Adora screamed her lungs raw with all her praises, once again receiving annoyed looks from the lady, but she didn't care. Catra, of course, wouldn't notice her in the many shouters, but she screamed anyway because the woman deserved it. And she seemed to enjoy it, too.

After minutes of this, the curtain closed eventually, and Adora was the first out of her seat. She didn't need to collect herself since she had no bag or purse or jacket, only her phone and a playbill.

Truth be told, she had no idea how long it took for actors to get ready to go home, to wind down and get out of costume and makeup, but she doubted it would be quick. Therefore, she could have made her way out slowly, but instead, she bolted outside and frantically searched for the backdoor until she was desperate enough to ask security.

The guy gave her a skeptical once-over and it took a while to explain to him that she didn't plan on murdering anyone, that she was just going to wait for her wife — which he didn't believe at all — until eventually another guard took pity on her and pointed in the right direction. She did receive the warning, though, to only get her autograph and get out. It seemed the second one didn't believe she was married to Catra either.

While she waited, and it was a long wait, she wondered why. Catra must have never mentioned her, which Adora supposed was fair. Or maybe she did, but the guards were only hired for the show days and didn't actually know anything about the actors. That was probably hopeful thinking, though.

Night had fallen while she had been inside and she had forgotten to buy a jacket when going shopping earlier. She knew she would survive, but she did start to shiver the longer she was rooted to her spot. Technically, some shop was probably still open, but she wouldn't dare move from her spot.

Behind her, a little crowd formed, which made her even more nervous. Sure, the park hadn't been exactly private, but this was truly not ideal. Not only was she sure that if Catra would lecture her in front of all these people, she would cry again, but more importantly, she didn't want to put the other on the spot. But leaving and not doing it wasn't an option either.

And despite her worries, it was nice to hear everyone gush about the performance. She tried to memorize every nice thing they said about Catra.

When the door finally opened, she perked up, but it was only Sea Hawk who came through. Now that he wasn't on stage, it was easy to see why Catra had called him dramatic. He was… certainly confident. Not in a bad way, particularly, but in the way that made him easily proclaim himself as someone great in every way.

A few more people filed out, whom she recognized as background characters and dancers. Plenty of people around her cried out for them, and few stopped to sign the playbills, but Adora kept her eyes trained on the door.

Maybe Catra got outside another way? Was there a different exit? Was Adora too late? Was she at the wrong place? It wasn't like she could leave and search somewhere else, though, because the crowd cornered her and pressed her to the little barricade that had been put up.

It wasn't until she had already lost all hope that four more figures stepped outside. It was Catra with Scorpia and two others, that she didn't recognize at all, not even from the stage. The people around her screamed for Catra to sign, to acknowledge, or whatever, and Adora tried her luck, too, but just like in the theater, there were too many voices.

She was right at the front, if only Catra would look, but the woman turned her face to the side, letting herself get shielded by Scorpia and a woman with purple hair, while the blonde in the group sent some glares to the crowd.

That was until their eyes met Adora and they started to grin. Since Catra was firmly behind the two others, they went and pointed her out to Scorpia, who stopped their entire group and firmly turned Catra to stare at the crowd.

Their eyes met instantly and she looked surprised, shocked even. And angry. That was to be expected.

For a second, it almost looked like she was going to run, but whatever the other three said to her must have convinced her to step closer instead.

The crowd seemed to notice how Catra fixated on her specifically and went eerily quiet.

"You were great", she said before every bit of courage she had left could leave her. "I knew you would be, but … I don't even have the words to describe how marvelously brilliant you were."

The woman scoffed, crossing her arms. "Not a great habit for a writer", she quipped, like everything was okay, but her tight face said clearly that it wasn't. "What are you doing here? I thought you had an important thing to go to."

"I did go to an important thing", she replied and saw the blonde put a hand over their heart in awe. Catra, however, did not look impressed. "I'm sorry", she said what she needed to say. "I cannot say that I didn't know that I was hurting you. I cannot say that I didn't notice you were sad. I kept making excuses and that wasn't okay. I should have talked to you. I should have made more time for you." She took a shaky breath — she really hated public speaking. "I can't change the past, but I want to try harder, I want to be better, I want to believe we're not over yet. I'm so sorry."

Catra stared at her, searching her face and contemplating her words, while everyone around them waited with bated breath. Even Sea Hawk was completely quiet.

Adora remembered the earlier thought she had. "I don't want to put you on the spot", she added quickly, ignoring a few disappointed interferences from behind her. "You don't have to answer right now. You can think about it for as long as you need. You can also yell at me more if you want to."

The other just shook her head. "You're such an idiot", was the final response and for some reason, it made Adora laugh.

"I know."

Catra sighed and ran a hand through her hair before she went through her purse to pull out a pen. Then she all but ripped the playbill from her hand to sign it. "I'll think about it", she said and handed it back.

"Thank you", Adora sighed with relief. It wasn't a definite answer, but it was more than she had hoped for.

The woman went on to sign more people's booklets for as long as the shocked and anticipatory silence lasted. The second people got a bit too excited again, she left with a happily smiling Scorpia, the purple-haired woman who babbled something, and the blond who gave Adora a nod and a smirk before following along.

Did she know them? Because the longer she looked at them, the more familiar they felt, but she had no idea who that was.

It was only once they were out of sight that Adora weaved her way through the crowd and left Sea Hawk to his fans — he had gone back to entertaining them rather quickly.

She made her way back to the hotel and passed out almost immediately, now that her anxiety had mostly worn off. With as long as she had waited, it had also gotten pretty late, so it really shouldn't have come as a surprise that she was out the second she hit the sheets.

The anxiety came back in full force the next morning when she had sleepily checked her phone and spotted a message from

Catra. That alone managed to wake her up, but the contents had her in panic mode again.

Catra had asked — more ordered than asked, but it didn't matter much to Adora — to meet at the park at ten. And it was already well past nine. At least she had gotten a good night's sleep.

Adora hurried to get changed, regretting that she didn't have time to take a shower, and then ran downstairs, earning herself some looks and glares again, which she once again ignored. Out in the streets, she thought through her options quickly. She didn't have time to wait for the bus, so she jumped into the next best taxi and got to the park barely on time.

Catra sat on a bench, sipping coffee and looking serene, when Adora arrived out of breath as she had run through half the park at top speed. Usually, she was in better shape, but lately, she didn't have time for much of anything, let alone going to the gym.

"Catra", she breathed out as she supported herself with her hands on her knees.

"Hey, Adora." It was so familiar and so taunting that it almost made her cry. "We need to talk."

She nodded and sat down on the bench, a respectable distance away. "Are you mad about yesterday? I'll admit, I didn't think that one through. I didn't mean to put you on the spot, I'm sorry."

"I am mad about a lot of things", Catra hissed and gave her an angry look. "Not yesterday, though. Yesterday might save your ass."

"Oh?" She reminded herself not to get her hopes up too much, but failed miserably as she felt her eyes water again.

The other sent her a glare, but took a deep breath. "I know this isn't just your fault. I was hurt and angry, and I didn't want to tell you because I didn't want to seem unsupportive. I should have told you", she admitted. "But you…" She pointed a finger at

Adora. "Could have asked. If you noticed, why didn't you ask? I wouldn't have told you, but you could have shown you cared and not ditched me on my birthday and made me think I was not important." Another deep breath. "I don't want to throw away five years. For some reason, I still love you, but I swear Adora, Sea Hawk is engaged to a lawyer, and if you ditch me one more time, I'll get that divorce."

Adora was stuck between happiness and fear, but mostly she was just relieved. "That's fair", she eagerly agreed before everything caught up with her. "Sea Hawk is engaged?" He had seemed to love the attention he was getting from any love-struck stranger yesterday, it was hard to believe he had a more stable relationship than they did.

"Yes." The look she received was still filled with anger, but it was a lot softer already. "And you'll go to the party with me. It's next Sunday."

Adora nodded. "Yes, I promise!"

Catra wasn't done yet, though. "You'll make time for me. You'll make time for my friends. More so, you'll make time for your friends, not whatever jerks you hang out with at those parties. Speaking of, you seriously have to learn how to say no. I'll go with you, but we'll discuss it and find times that work for us both. You do not need to do this every day."

She nodded again. "I know", she admitted quietly.

"I'm not done. You'll get a proper routine again. You need breaks, and sleep, and evidently a workout", she kept going, pointedly looking at her. "I'll keep working with Perfuma and get my anger under control. And learn to talk about my feelings. I'll come to the stupid parties that we agree on, and you won't leave me to get drunk with the bartender. DT is cool and all, but I'm not doing that again. I … I just want you to stay with me. Not act like I could just as well not exist."

"I will." Adora carefully reached out to touch Catra's hand. "I will work on it. I'll do whatever it takes to make this work again. We're in this together. You've got my back, and I've got yours?" She mirrored the words she had said once when she had been trying to encourage Catra to take a leap.

Catra nodded, but held up a finger before she could release the breath she was holding. "One more thing", she then said and Adora nodded, urging her to say it. "We'll see Perfuma together. We're doing this properly and with professional help", she demanded.

"I'll take a therapist over a lawyer any day", she told her and finally breathed out, relief flooding her entire system. She couldn't believe she was actually getting another chance. "I love you." It slipped out, just like that, and she got nervous again that it might be too soon.

But Catra only sighed. "I love you, too."

Adora smiled. Even though it hadn't exactly sounded like the other was very happy with that circumstance, it was the first time in a long time that she had actually said it back. The whole sentence in full and not some vague abbreviation of it.

Also, for the first time in a long time, she didn't have to make herself believe it when she thought that things would be fine now.

They would be okay. That she was absolutely sure of.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to everyone who read this. I hope you enjoyed this story <333
I tried to make it into a happy ending, and though I believe it is rather open-ended, I think I managed to give it a hopeful feeling, at least?

Lastly, I also hope you can enjoy the holidays and stay hydrated <33

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!